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A Response to "Nuclear War: The Rising Risk, and How We Stop It"

The New York Times article "At the Brink" by W.J. Hennigan is a scary reminder that nuclear war is not just something from history books. Even though we haven't had a nuclear war in a long time, the author argues that the risk is rising today. The main problem is that we stopped "imagining" how bad it could be, which makes it more likely to happen. For the first time in 30 years, countries are building more weapons, and we are starting a new arms race.

The most interesting part of the article is that the U.S. and Ukraine have actually been planning for a nuclear attack for two years. Hennigan talks about a "Tiger Team" of experts who created a "playbook" for the President to use if Russia uses a nuclear weapon. In 2022, U.S. intelligence thought there was a 50-50 chance—like a coin flip—that Russia would use a "tactical" nuclear weapon to stop Ukrainian soldiers. This shows that the danger is very real and not just a theory.

The article explains that Russia has about 2,000 "tactical" nuclear weapons. These are smaller than the bombs used in WWII, and some can even fit inside an artillery shell. Because they are smaller, some people think they are "usable" in a normal war. But the author says this is dangerous. Our safety depends on "deterrence," which is the idea that nobody will start a nuclear war because they know they will be destroyed too. If someone uses a small bomb, that safety is gone, and everything could spiral out of control. Hennigan gives a very clear and "alarmist" description of what happens after a blast. He talks about "black rain" filled with radiation, people getting sick with nausea and internal bleeding, and babies being born with defects. But the damage isn't just where the bomb hits. A scientific study says that even using 1% of the world's nuclear

weapons could cause a global famine. This would kill millions of people in places like the Middle East and Africa because the soot in the air would block the sun and stop crops from growing.

In the end, the article says that the "safety net" of treaties that kept us safe during the Cold War is almost gone. Only one major treaty is left, and it expires in 2026. Without these agreements and better communication between leaders, the risk of a mistake is very high. We need to remember the "horrifying aftermath" of these weapons so that we work harder to avoid them. Having a family and living a normal life shouldn't be at risk because of a nuclear mistake.